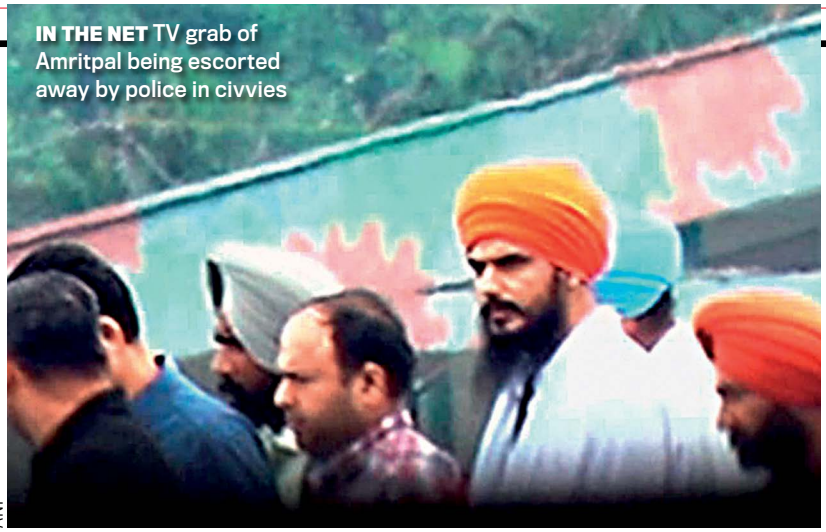


IN THE NET TV grab of Amritpal being escorted away by police in civvies

ANI

security agencies to hold them in preventive custody without showing cause.

In the past 35 days, the intelligence agencies, along with the Punjab police, have cracked down on Amritpal's international network, believing he was mobilising resources from the Pakistan ISI's network in West Asia to fuel the Khalistan narrative and divide Punjab on communal lines. Sources say the agencies will be confronting Amritpal with the evidence gathered from his arrested aide, actor and alleged WPD financier Daljit Kalsi, and probe his links to terrorists Avtar Khanda, a UK-based Khalistan Liberation Force activist, and Babbar Khalsa International's Paramjit Singh Pamma.

Soon after the arrest, IG Sukhchain Singh Gill, who was leading the operation, told reporters that they had cornered him in the gurdwara, but there are conflicting reports on this. One thing is clear, though: the WPD chief was running out of options after aide Papalpreet was arrested on April 10. On April 21, his wife Kirandeep Kaur was not allowed to board a flight to London from the Amritsar airport, with the local police saying she was required for questioning. Former Akal Takht *jathedar* (head priest) Jasbir Rode, a nephew of Bhindranwale, apparently played a crucial role in facilitating the 'surrender'. It was at the same Rode gurudwara that Amritpal rose to fame after the *dastarbandi* (turban-tying ceremony) in September-end after which he took over WPD reins.

Punjab chief minister Bhagwant Mann, too, was on social media after the arrest, claiming victory for his Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) regime in "taming the anti-national elements". Mann's government had been in the dock after an Amritpal-led mob laid siege to a police station in Amritsar's Ajnala on February 25. For the once-formidable Punjab Police, this had come as an open challenge. A week later, Mann was nudged by Union home minister Amit Shah to take action and provided with 18 CRPF and Rapid Action Force (RAF) battalions. In fact, during the bypoll campaign for the Jalandhar Lok Sabha seat, Mann had got flak for not being able to take down Amritpal. However, now the shoe is on the other foot, with Opposition parties like the Congress, the Sukhbir Badal-led Shiromani Akali Dal and Simranjit Mann's Shiromani Akali Dal (Amritsar) criticising the CM for excessive use of force in the crackdown. Mann has taken a big chance, and now risks angering the *panthic* (religious) Sikh voters as well.

AMRITPAL'S ARREST IS NO INDICATOR THAT SIKH RADICALISM IS ON THE WANE. CM MANN NOW RISKS ANGERING PANTHIC VOTERS TOO

Indeed, taking Amritpal out of the equation is by no means an indicator that Sikh radicalism is on the wane. There is a long list of festering religious, social and political issues and the whirlwind entry of Amritpal only provided a vent for it. No wonder his openly pro-Khalistan speeches and calls for supporters to bear arms and be ready to "sacrifice" themselves for the "Sikh cause" went viral on social media. A young propagandist with a seamless ability to switch from chaste Punjabi to fluent English, he soon found an avid following among the state's disgruntled youth, fed up as they were with shrinking economic opportunities and the vacuum in the state's panthic politics.

The arrest, or surrender, of Amritpal happened a week before 'Khalistan Day' on April 29, which Sikh radical groups across the world commemorate as the day in 1986 when several militant groups convened at the *sarbat khalsa* at Akal Takht, and declared their resolve to fight for a separate Sikh state. Every year, pro-Khalistan marches and protests start from this day and go on till June 6, the fateful day Operation Blue Star got under way in 1984. Last year, radical Sikhs in Patiala clashed with fringe Hindutva groups taking out a 'Khalistan Murdabad' march on the day, leaving several injured and a local Kali temple vandalised.

Amritpal was putting pressure on the current Akal Takht *jathedar*, Giani Harpreet Singh, to convene a similar gathering of *sarbat khalsa*. However, the clergy was holding out. Amritpal was also not fully trusted by the other radical groups; many of them had a sneaking suspicion that he was an "agency *da banda*" or a spy of the security agencies.

The radical groups keep an unremitting focus on all contentious issues. This includes the release of 22 convicted Sikh militants lodged in jails across the country, and justice for the 2015 Guru Granth Sahib desecration incident and the subsequent violence. On April 24, Morinda, a small trading town in Ropar district, was tense after yet another 'sac-